

How to Influence Peers in the Workplace

Vasanthi Srinivasan

Peer influence is a critical part of being an effective professional. Good working relationships give us several other benefits: our work becomes more enjoyable when we have good relationships with those around us. It is much easier to get feedback on our ideas and also to find more innovative and creative ways of looking at problems. Strong peer relationships allow us to be more engaged in the workplace.

Several years ago as a consultant I was involved in doing a culture audit of the State Agriculture department in India. This department had done some outstanding work on agricultural practices and had won an award. This was a rather unusual occurrence in the State. When we analyzed the employee survey data, we found that most employees attributed their outstanding success to the peer work group. One of the scientists mentioned in the survey document that his motivation to come to work were his friends. Many decades later, Gallup, the consulting firm which conducts employee engagement surveys mentioned that employees who had a friend in the workplace reported higher level of engagement. We are all social beings and many of us spend a significant part of our day at work. Therefore, peer relationships play a significant role in our satisfaction in the workplace.

Peer influence occurs in three ways: through **relationships**, **expertise** and **support**.

Peer relationships are built on trust, mutual respect, reciprocity and open communication. They require investments in terms of time, resources, effort and energy. As peers, when we make these investments, we often find that opportunities and networks open up to us, which hitherto were not available. Several years ago, when an organization was going through an acquisition, my former peer suggested my name for a due diligence audit. When the firm approached me, I was curious as to how they got my reference. The CEO of the firm mentioned that my peer had given them my reference. We must bear in mind that as we are progressing in the organization, our peers are also progressing and building their own networks. Many times, these networks are not overlapping. Peer relationships provide opportunities to access such non-overlapping networks.

A second way, to influence peers is through **expertise**. Expertise is the capacity to influence the behavior of other people through one's knowledge or skills. Expertise derives from the possession of certain unique understanding, technology, information or some insights. This expertise is personal and since it is centered with the individual, it is difficult to replicate. Peers who do not possess the expertise are likely to value the same in the accomplishment of their goals. Therefore, expertise has a key role to play in influencing peers.

Finally, **Peer support** also plays a critical role. In a paper by Langford, Bowsher, Maloney and Lillis, the authors observed that support could be in four areas: emotional support (caring, empathy, trust), instrumental support (providing tangible aid or goods), informational support (assisting in problem solving), and appraisal support (affirmation or communicating realistic self-evaluation). Social support is also known to buffer against stress (Bakker, Schaufeli, et al., 2006), emotional exhaustion and burnout. Positive coworker interactions are related to feelings of wellbeing and work satisfaction. All of these in turn impact the well being of employees.

In conclusion, being an effective peer requires us to invest in making the effort and expending the time, to build relationships, develop expertise and finally, provide support to others. This journey of investing in peer relationships will yield results in the long-term career development.